

Enrollment and Eligibility

Individuals become eligible to enroll in the plan during the annual open enrollment period, or during a special enrollment period following a qualifying life event. Dependents, including a spouse or domestic partner and children up to age 26, may be added to a member's coverage. Proof of eligibility, such as a marriage certificate or birth certificate, may be required within 30 days of the qualifying event.

Effective Date of Coverage and Disenrollment

Coverage generally becomes effective on the first day of the month following enrollment, provided the enrollment form and any required premium are received on time. Members may voluntarily disenroll by submitting a written request. Involuntary disenrollment may occur for nonpayment of premium after a required grace period, for material misrepresentation on an enrollment application, or for moving outside the plan's service area.

Coordination of Benefits with Other Insurance

If a member has coverage under more than one health plan, the plans coordinate benefits to determine which plan pays first (the primary plan) and which pays second (the secondary plan). The primary plan pays benefits as if no other coverage existed. The secondary plan may then pay some or all of the remaining eligible expenses, up to the amount it would have paid had it been primary. Members must notify the plan of any other health coverage they have.

Prior Authorization and Utilization Review

Certain services require prior authorization to confirm they are medically necessary and covered under the plan before they are provided. Requests for prior authorization may be submitted by the member's provider. The plan reviews requests using nationally recognized clinical criteria and generally responds within 14 calendar days for a standard request, or 72 hours for an expedited request when a delay could seriously jeopardize the member's health.

Grievance and Appeals Process

A grievance is a complaint about the quality of care or service received, not involving a denial of coverage. An appeal is a request to review a denial of coverage or payment. Appeals have two levels: a first-level internal appeal reviewed by the plan, and, if denied, a second-level appeal that may include an independent external review by a party not affiliated with the plan. Members may request an expedited appeal when a standard timeframe could seriously jeopardize their health.

Provider Network Participation Rules

Providers who wish to join the plan's network must meet credentialing standards, including verification of licensure, education, malpractice history, and board certification where applicable. Network providers agree to accept the plan's negotiated rates as payment in full for covered services, other than applicable member cost-sharing. Providers are recredentialed on a periodic basis to confirm continued compliance with network standards.

Coverage Determinations and Exceptions

A coverage determination is the plan's decision about whether a service or drug is covered and how much the member owes. Members or their providers may request an exception to standard coverage rules, such as requesting a non-formulary drug when formulary alternatives have proven ineffective or caused adverse reactions. Exception requests require supporting documentation from the prescribing or treating provider.

Fraud, Waste, and Abuse Prevention

The plan maintains a program to detect, prevent, and report health care fraud, waste, and abuse. Examples of fraud include billing for services not rendered or misrepresenting a diagnosis to obtain coverage for a non-covered service. Members and providers may report suspected fraud confidentially through the plan's fraud hotline. Confirmed cases of fraud may result in termination of membership or network participation and referral to appropriate authorities.

Member Privacy and Confidentiality

The plan protects the privacy of members' personal health information in accordance with applicable privacy laws. Health information is used and disclosed only as necessary for treatment, payment, and health care operations, or as otherwise permitted or required by law. Members have the right to request a copy of their records held by the plan and to request corrections to inaccurate information.

Contact Information and Resources

For questions about this manual or your coverage, contact Member Services at 1-800-555-0100 or visit member.samplehealthplan.example. Written correspondence, including appeals and grievances, may be mailed to: Sample Health Insurance Company, Attn: Member Appeals, P.O. Box 55555, Sample City, ST 00000.